

When you teach me, I become something else. Why should 20 crore children who drop out of school between the ages of six and 14 be denied that privilege? Why should every child not be like 17-year-old Swapna Patnaik from East Singhbhum, who studied in a free school, Prem Jyoti Prangan, set up with help from TISCO in Jamshedpur, and got 83 per cent in her Class X boards? Why should Ranjit Kumar Bahri, son of a 42-year-old autorickshaw driver, not be able to learn a computer course at Delhi's Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan and get at least a clerical job that pays him Rs 10,000 a month?

Even as we struggle with issues of basic education—only 11 per cent of school leavers actually make it to

college—new ways of thinking are sweeping the cobwebs away. The new HRD Minister, Kapil Sibal, seems an enthusiastic, though somewhat confusing proponent of several simultaneous changes, but it is clear that the time for talk has ended. Already enough has been done on reforming the pedagogy and practice of education. Some are just going ahead with the change, regardless. Take former Thermax chairperson Anu Aga, who has adopted two municipal schools in Pune and converted them to English medium. Or another similarly inclined philanthropic individual Rohini Nilekani, who has put her money into the Public Health Foundation of India which runs public health courses at three new, currently rented, campuses in Gurgaon, Gandhinagar and Hyderabad, in order to fill the yawning gap in professionals in this area.

At both the high and low ends of the technological spectrum, other individuals have created empires of the mind. Take Vijay Thadani and Rajendra Pawar's NIIT. With an initial investment of Rs 1 crore, of which Rs 15 lakh were from their personal savings, they set up a software-producing giant on the McDonald's franchise model. At the other end, take an institution such as the Jawaharlal Nehru Centre for Advanced Scientific Research which was set up by the formidable chemist CNR Rao in 1989 at a cost of Rs 4 crore to promote high-end scientific research and training. Sometimes, individuals have simply exercised their right to autonomy as Narendra Jadhav did as vice-chancellor of the University of Pune, leaving it with a deficit of Rs 156 crore but proud of spending every rupee for the right cause.

These are men and women who have not been defeated by red tape, just as the government should not be daunted by the enormity of its task. As our guest columnists have written, practically everything is a priority, whether it is school education, vocational education or higher education. The inept regulatory author-

ities at various levels, especially in professional education, have resulted in privatisation by stealth, as Deepak Nayyar calls it. The new minister has smartly laid out the goals of education reform: access to education at all levels, which is far behind the global average; equity, which for both SC/ST and certain minorities is even below the poor national average; and quality, which is evident only in a few centres of excellence.

Yes, there are questions to be debated. Should India be relegated to a blue-collar s&t nation, as scientist Roddam Narasimha rues, or should it try to revive the drive to do pure science, as Jawaharlal Nehru had envisaged? Should corporates fund institutions without waiting for the government to accord its approval, finding ways to beat the system by offering diplomas or ensuring state university accreditation or should they wait till the regulatory mechanism is perfect? Should we bask in the glory of Barack Obama telling American schoolchildren to learn from India ("The Chinese, the Indians, they're coming at us, and they're coming at us hard, and they're hungry, and they're really buckling down") or try putting each child into a classroom, out of factories, tea stalls and off the streets?

As Manish Sabharwal, of TeamLease Services, which has built its equity by re-training and then employing vanilla graduates for specific jobs in the service sector, says there is no shortage of ideas. They're falling off the table, he says, and progress lies in reducing the transmission losses between theory and practice. It's a question of wanting to implement the ideas. As the individuals and institutions singled out here show, sometimes it's best to start small.

Report Card Blues

There is a **40 per cent** shortage of trained faculty in higher education institutions in India.

In 2007, **half** of the children in government schools couldn't read or write even after attending school for four-five years.

India has the **third** highest number of students in the higher education sector after China and the US.

The country earns **Rs 2,000 cr** every year from 50,000 foreign students who come here for studies.

Indian universities charge about **\$10,000** for a course in business management whereas in the US it would cost \$80,000.

9.19 per cent of rural India's primary to higher secondary schools had a single classroom in 2007-08.

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